Returns and Refunds

Document code RR-01. Version 1.0. Effective 1 January 2024. This is a synthetic policy for the fictional company Northwind Gifts. It is used only for a software demonstration.

1. Scope and definitions

1.1 Who this policy covers. This policy covers orders placed by retail customers on the Northwind Gifts website. Wholesale accounts follow Section 7 instead of Sections 2, 5 and 6.

1.2 Delivery date. The delivery date is the date the courier marks the parcel as delivered. All return windows count from the delivery date, not the order date.

1.3 Business days. A business day is Monday to Friday, excluding public holidays in England.

2. Standard return window

2.1 Retail return window. A retail customer may return an unused item for any reason within 30 days of the delivery date.

2.2 Condition of returned items. Items must be unused, in the original packaging, with all labels and tags attached. Items that show signs of use may be refunded at 50 percent of the item price.

2.3 Christmas extended window. Items delivered between 1 November and 24 December may be returned until 31 January of the following year. The extended window applies to retail orders only.

2.4 Proof of purchase. The customer must give the order number or the order confirmation email. Returns without proof of purchase may be refused.

3. Items that cannot be returned

3.1 Personalised items. Items that are engraved, printed or made to order cannot be returned for change of mind. They can be returned if they are faulty or damaged.

3.2 Food and perishable goods. Food hampers, chocolates and other perishable goods cannot be returned once delivered, unless they arrive damaged or past their best before date.

3.3 Final Sale items. Items marked Final Sale at the time of purchase cannot be returned for change of mind. Final Sale does not affect the customer's right to a remedy for faulty goods.

3.4 Opened hygiene items. Opened candles, bath products and cosmetics cannot be returned for change of mind.

4. Damaged and faulty items

4.1 Faulty items. Faulty items are handled under the Warranty and Product Quality policy. A faulty item is not subject to the 30 day window in clause 2.1.

4.2 Damaged items. A customer must report an item damaged in transit within 7 days of the delivery date and send photographs of the item and the outer box. Northwind Gifts will then send a free replacement or give a full refund, at the customer's choice.

4.3 Keep the item rule. If a damaged or wrong item costs less than £10, the customer is refunded and does not need to send it back.

4.4 Wrong item sent. If Northwind Gifts sends the wrong item, the customer may choose a replacement or a full refund. Return postage is free. The customer must report the error within 14 days of the delivery date.

5. Refunds

5.1 Refund method. Refunds are paid to the original payment method. Refunds are not paid in cash.

5.2 Refund timing. Northwind Gifts pays the refund within 5 business days after the returned item passes inspection.

5.3 Return postage. For a change of mind return, the customer pays return postage. A flat fee of £4.95 is deducted from the refund if the customer uses the prepaid label. Return postage is free for faulty, damaged or wrong items.

5.4 Delivery charges. The original standard delivery charge is refunded only if the whole order is returned because of a fault, damage or an error by Northwind Gifts.

5.5 Loyalty points. Loyalty points earned on a refunded item are removed from the customer's balance, as set out in the Loyalty Programme policy.

6. Exchanges and store credit

6.1 Exchanges. A customer may exchange an item once for a different size, colour or product, within the return window in clause 2.1. If the new item costs more, the customer pays the difference.

6.2 Gift returns. If the item is returned by someone other than the buyer and has a gift receipt, the value is given as store credit. Store credit is valid for 12 months.

7. Wholesale returns

7.1 Wholesale return window. A wholesale customer may return unused stock within 14 days of the delivery date. This is shorter than the retail window in clause 2.1.

7.2 Restocking fee. A restocking fee of 15 percent of the item value is charged on wholesale returns for change of mind. No fee is charged if the goods are faulty or Northwind Gifts made an error.

7.3 Return authorisation. A wholesale customer must ask for a return authorisation number before sending goods back. Returns without this number are not accepted.

7.4 Damaged wholesale goods. Wholesale customers must report damage or shortages within 48 hours of delivery. Claims made after 48 hours may be refused.

7.5 Credit notes. Wholesale customers on credit terms receive a credit note instead of a refund to a payment card. The credit note is applied to the next invoice.

7.6 No Christmas extension. The Christmas extended window in clause 2.3 does not apply to wholesale orders.

8. Cancellations

8.1 Cancelling before dispatch. A retail customer may cancel an order for free before it is dispatched. Orders are usually dispatched on the same day if placed before 2pm.

8.2 Cancelling after dispatch. After dispatch, the order cannot be cancelled. The customer may return the goods under Section 2.

9. Disputes

9.1 Escalation. If a customer disagrees with a returns decision, the customer can ask for a review. Northwind Gifts replies to the review request within 10 business days.

9.2 Chargebacks. Customers should contact Northwind Gifts before starting a card chargeback. A chargeback started while a return is in progress may delay the refund.